

# CHIVALRY AND courtly love

## MEDIEVAL EUROPE

Part of the pageantry of noble and royal life, the concepts of chivalry and courtly love arose in the courts of medieval Europe. Both ideas helped to govern the behavior and relationships of the elite. The word “chivalry” came into use in the late 11th century. It means “horsemanship” in Old French but can refer to brave deeds in battle or a group of knights. Chivalry’s most important role was as a social code of behavior for knights to follow. Its main features included believing in and defending the Church, championing good causes, protecting the weak, and remaining faithful to one’s overlord.

Intermingled with chivalry was courtly love. Developed in present-day France during the late 11th and early 12th centuries, the idea of courtly love emphasized that a knight should honorably serve his paramour by following her every command, even if it meant death. In the many poems and songs



### ◀ A culture of romance

A scene of romantic courtly love is captured on this embroidered 14th-century French purse. The wreath the young girl holds in her left hand symbolizes her virginity.

inspired by courtly love, knights would be as obedient to their lover as their king. In the tales of King Arthur, which experienced a resurgence in popularity during the age of

chivalry, the knight Lancelot does the lady Guinevere’s bidding, betraying his king. Love was thought to inspire skill and great deeds in battle, improving a knight’s character.

Courtly love placed romance and mutual attraction above all else, but this was at odds with the reality of the medieval era—a time in which elite relationships were based on strategic marriage alliances. The chivalric code urged knights to show respect toward women. In practice, they often failed to live up to the ideal, especially when it came



**“ANY ... LADY OF  
NOBLE DISPOSITION  
... DESERVES TO BE  
SOUGHT AFTER.”**

MARIE DE FRANCE, “EQUITAN,” 12TH-CENTURY POEM